proper administrative system to even let me know if I could study and work simultaneously. With no guidelines, I registered for MTech, but hardly six months into the course, some administrative officer inquired how I could work and study at the same time. I asked for the rules, but there was none.

Sarabhai had a suggestion: study something on liquid propulsion, my passion, in a foreign university. He could send me on study deputation with a grant if I got admission. I was not sure if Princeton would consider me two years after I did not take up the course, which I was offered, but I applied.

Soon came good news-bad news—I was selected to Princeton, but my course will be on solid propulsion under Prof. Summerfield, a famous solid propulsion specialist. I made my option clear and the university allowed me to choose another professor who would guide me on a masters in chemical rocket propulsion, which was closer to liquid propulsion. Prof. Lugi L Crocco was the man, but he would not take any students now. Clinching that was the first challenge in Princeton. Reaching Princeton itself would have been tough, but for the influence and interest of Vikram Sarabhai.

The letter from Princeton came in mid-August 1969 and I had to join in September. Getting a visa would not be difficult as a student, but those days getting foreign exchange was cumbersome and time consuming. And then, there were government procedures to be followed to send a scientist abroad for study. But when Sarabhai wanted something done, nothing came in the way.

In a matter of few minutes, a committee was constituted to ‘evaluate and authorise’ my project. The panel comprising E V Chitins and H G S Murthy gave the green signal. I was cleared.

The government of India would pay for my air tickets and I would get a monthly subsistence allowance of $210. My salary would continue to be credited to my bank in India. That was more than a fair deal, but getting foreign exchange to the tune of $1,260 in a few weeks continued to be a tough proposition.

Sarabhai pulled strings. Given that he was among the few in the world who could call Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on the phone whenever he